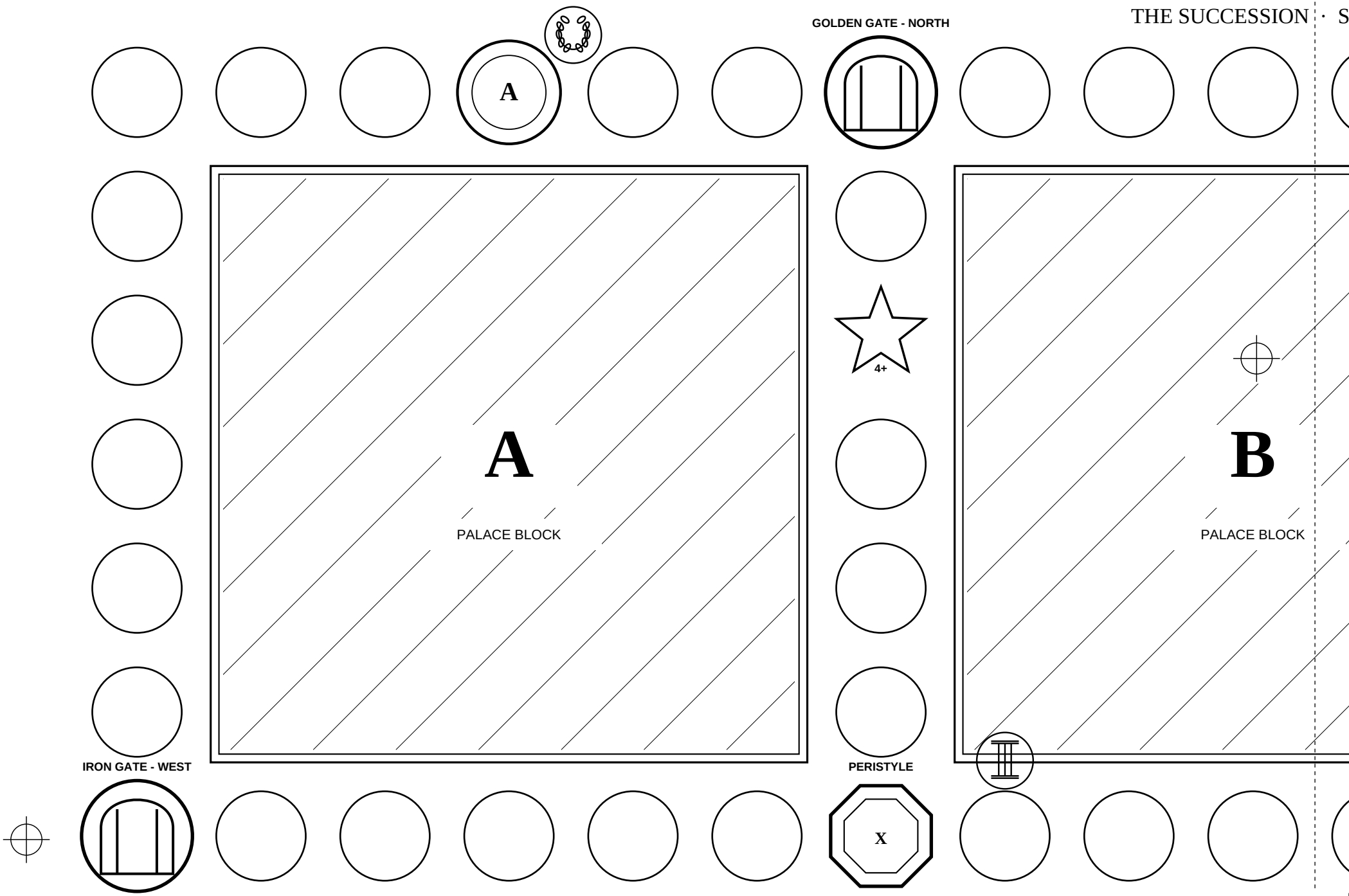
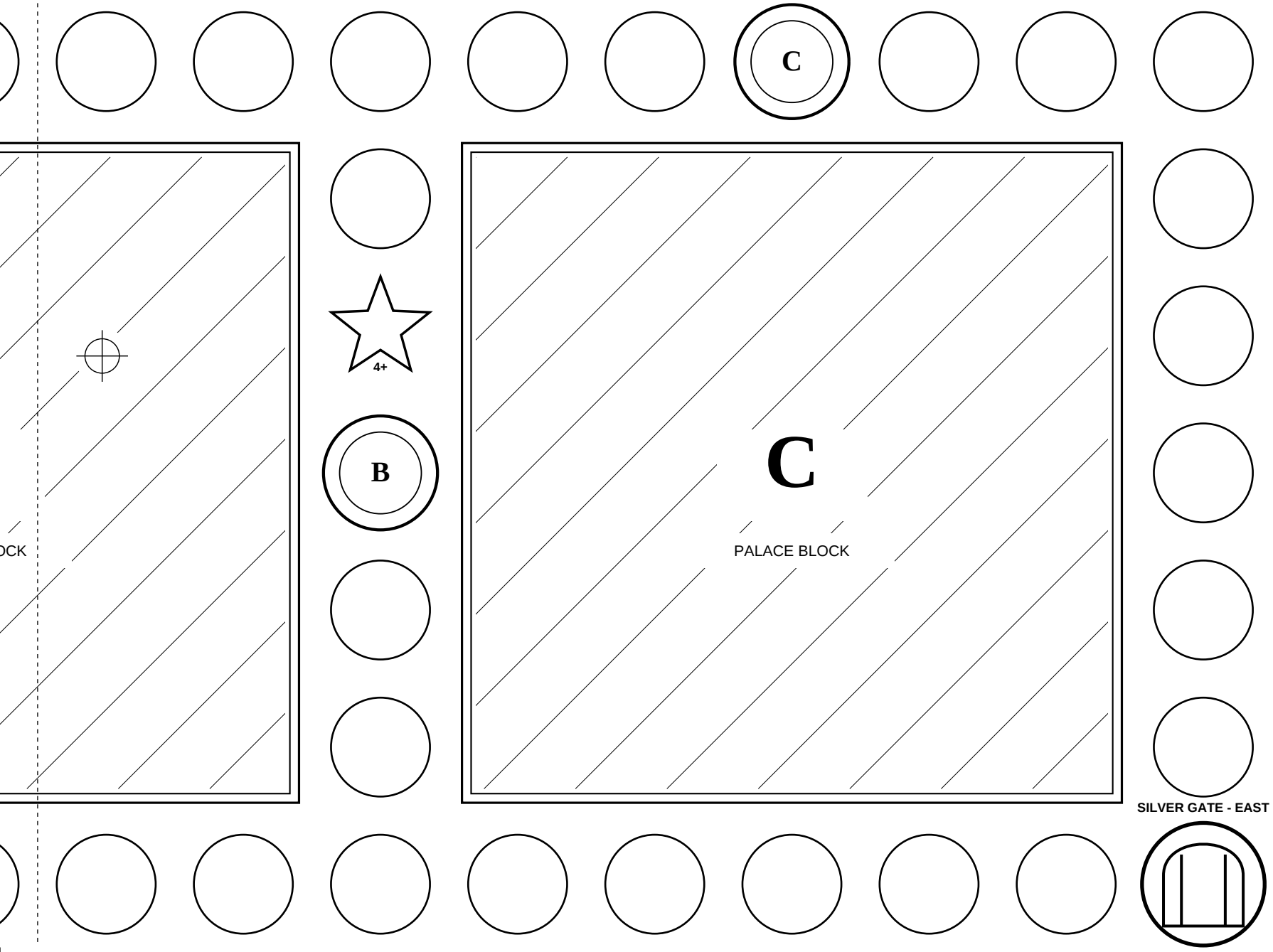
DIOCLETIAN

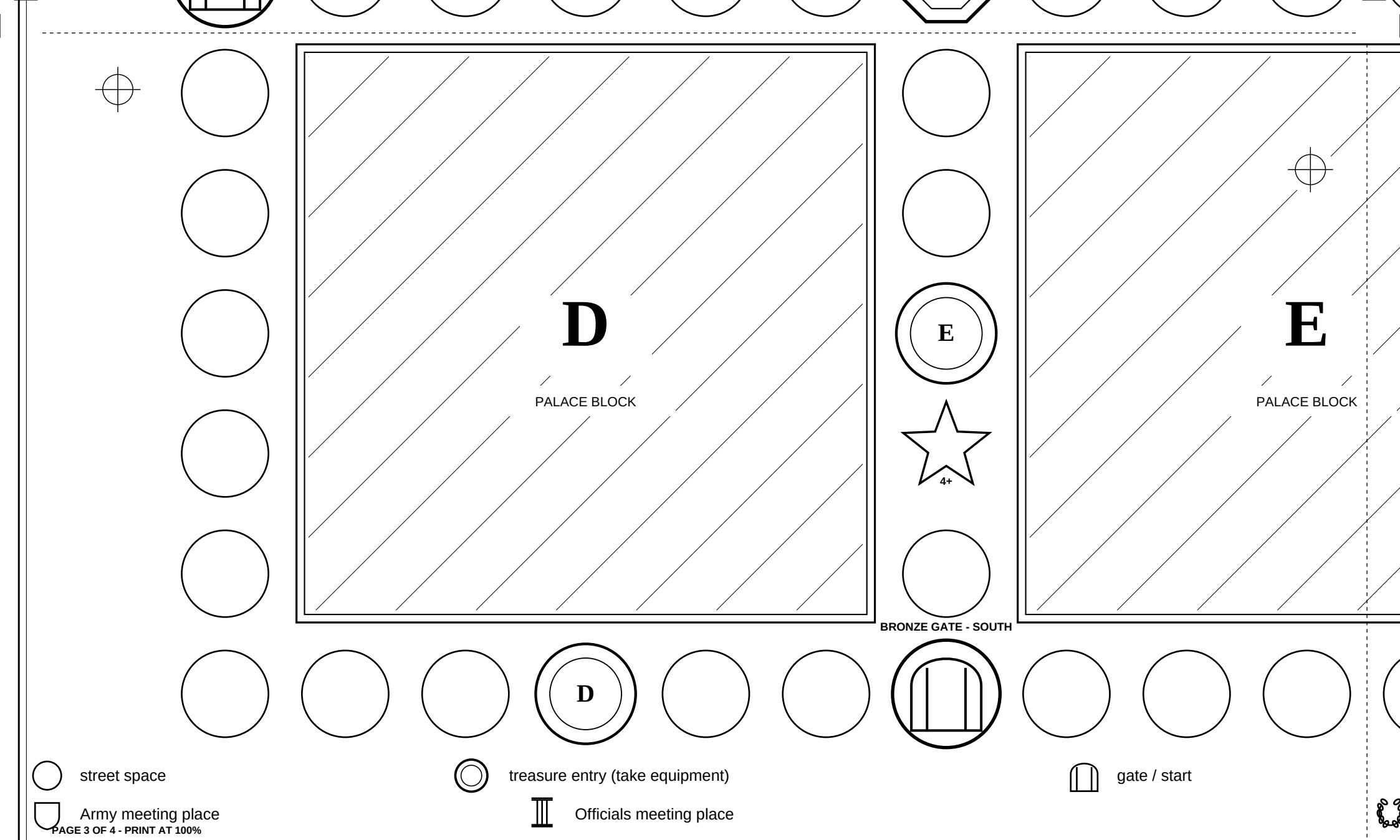
THE SUCCESSION · S

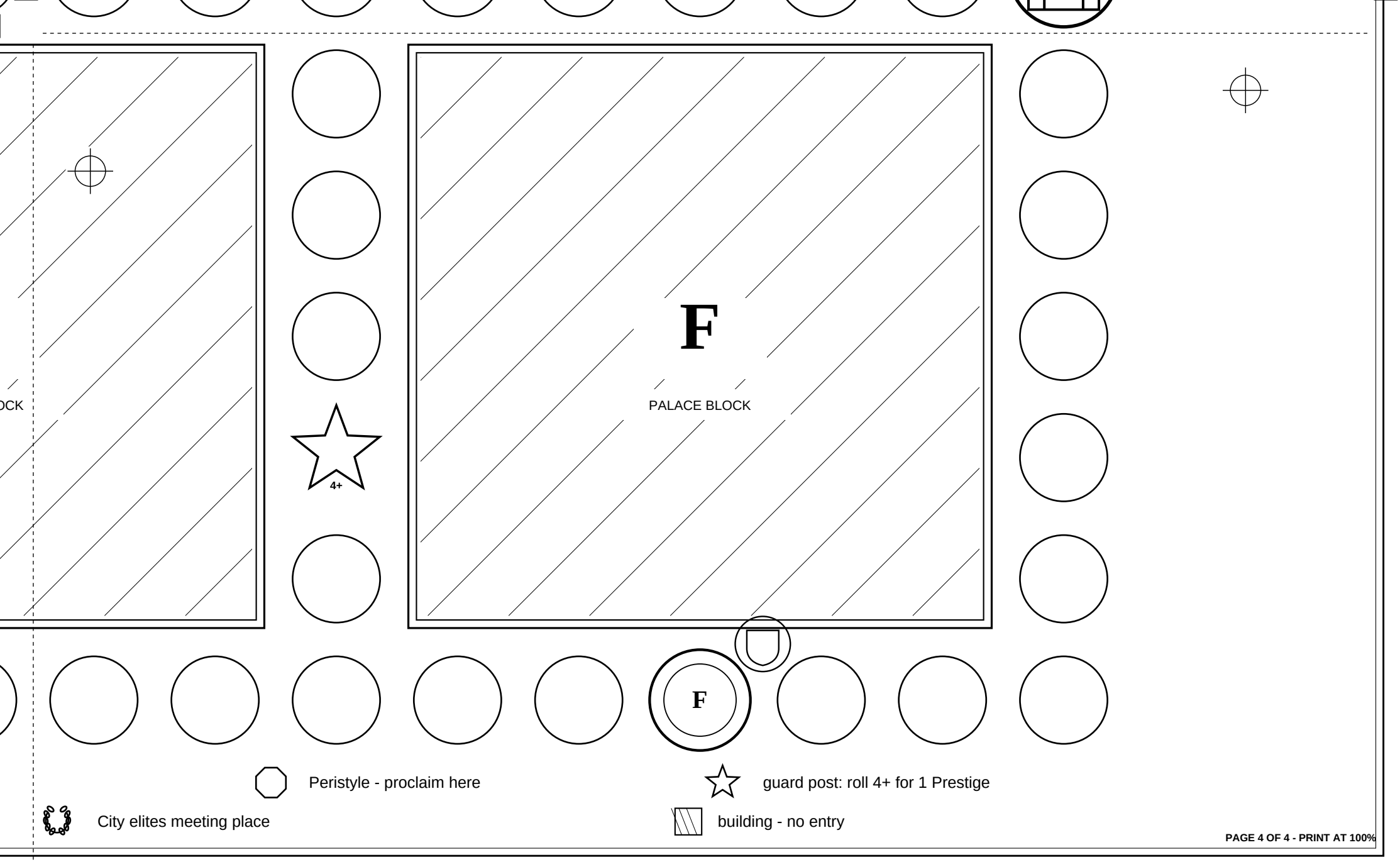


AN'S PALACE

ON · SIX TREASURES




D
PALACE BLOCK
E
4+
E
PALACE BLOCK
BRONZE GATE - SOUTH
D
street space
treasure entry (take equipment)
gate / start
Army meeting place
Officials meeting place


F
PALACE BLOCK
4+
F
Peristyle - proclaim here
guard post: roll 4+ for 1 Prestige
City elites meeting place
building - no entry

PRINT AND ASSEMBLE

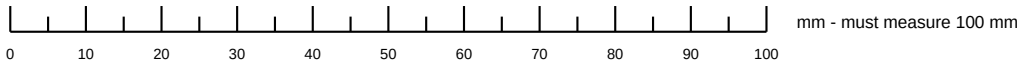
everything prints on plain A4, black ink, 100% scale

1. Print

- Board file 'dioclet-board-4xA4': four pages, A4 LANDSCAPE, scale 100% (Actual size). Do not tick 'fit to page'.
- Every other file: A4 portrait, 100%.
- Any black-and-white printer works. Single-sided printing is fine.
- Paper is enough. Card stock makes the cards nicer, but is not required.

2. Check the scale

Measure the ruler below with any ruler before you print the whole kit. If it does not measure exactly 100 mm, set the print scale to 100% and try again.



3. Cut

- Cut out the six treasure cards, the six card backs, and every token on the tokens page.
- Fold each pawn in half on the middle line and tape or glue it so it stands up. A coin works just as well.
- Leave the four board pages uncut for now - they are trimmed during assembly (next page).

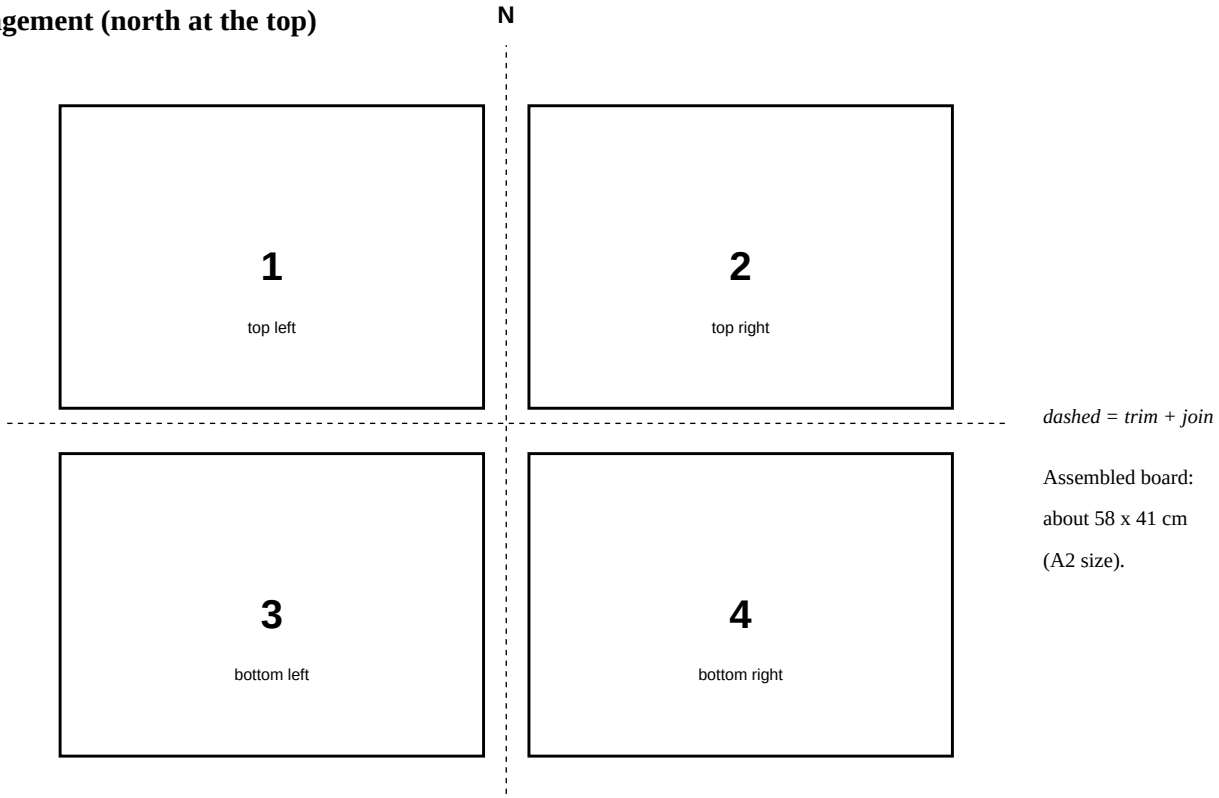
PRINT AND ASSEMBLE

tape four pages into one board (about 58 x 41 cm)

4. Assemble the board

- Cut each board page along BOTH dashed lines - one upright, one across. Cut exactly on the dashes. Each page becomes one quadrant of the board; two thin strips fall away.
- Lay the quadrants in a 2 x 2 square: page 1 top left, page 2 top right, page 3 bottom left, page 4 bottom right (diagram below).
- Butt the cut edges together. The printed circles, letters and lines must continue across each join without a step, and the small circle-crosses near each join must sit level with their neighbours on the next page.
- Tape every join from the back with any tape.
- Optional: glue the finished board onto a folder or thin cardboard. Not required for play.

Arrangement (north at the top)



No printer at hand? Any print shop can print these PDFs from a USB stick - nothing here needs an account.

DIOCLETIAN'S PALACE

The Succession - rules for four players

Read pages 1 to 3 before the first turn. Use pages 4 to 6 for the succession phase and common questions.

The goal

What you are trying to do

Diocletian has retired. Four rivals prepare a claim to the throne. Collect equipment to become strong, earn Prestige to pay for help, and win the support of two of the three factions in the city. Then stand at the Peristyle, the great crossing of the palace, and proclaim your claim. If none of your three rivals can stop it, the throne is yours.

What you need

- This printed kit: the board (four taped pages), six treasure cards, the tokens, and one player sheet per person.
- Two ordinary six-sided dice for movement, and one six-sided die for fights (any die works for both - you just need three dice in total).
- A small pawn per player. Coins or buttons work. The paper pawns in this kit also work.
- About 45 to 75 minutes for four players learning the game.

How to set up

1. Assemble the board (see the assembly sheet). Each player picks a pawn and a player sheet, and writes their name on it.
2. Shuffle the six treasure cards face down. Place one on each treasure entry, the double circles marked A to F. Then turn two of the six face up at random - everyone sees those two treasures from the start.
3. Give each player a random gate: Golden (north), Silver (east), Bronze (south), or Iron (west). Put your pawn on your gate.
4. Choose a starting player at random. The start moves one seat clockwise at the beginning of every round.

DIOCLETIAN'S PALACE - RULES

The Succession

Your turn

One turn, three steps

1. Roll two dice. The total is the maximum number of steps you may take.
2. Move your pawn along the street circles, one circle per step, north, south, east or west. You may stop before using the whole roll and you may pass through circles occupied by other pawns.
3. Do one action where you stand - or do nothing. Taking treasure, standing guard, duelling, gaining support, proclaiming and revealing a district (with the galea) are all actions. You never do two of these on the same turn.

What counts as movement

The white circles are streets. The hatched blocks are buildings: nobody walks through them. All movement and all distances are counted along street circles, not across buildings.

Guard duty and duels are actions of a moving turn: you must move at least one circle first. Taking treasure, gaining support, claiming the checkpoint and proclaiming may be done without moving.

Rounds and turns

A round is one turn for every player, in clockwise order from the starting player. After the last player, a new round begins and the start moves one seat clockwise, so nobody always plays first.

Treasure and equipment

The six treasures

Each treasure entry (double circle, A to F) holds one face-down card: pugio, pilum, galea, scutum, gladius, or lorica segmentata. Two of the six start face up. End your move on an entry to take that card's action: reveal the card to everyone and mark the item on your player sheet.

Every player can collect every item once. The cards stay on the board face up once revealed; they are never taken away, stolen, or lost. If you are the first to stop at an entry, you learn for everyone what waits there.

What each item does

Every item carries one ability that lasts the whole game:

Item	Mark	Ability
Gladius	sword	+1 to your attack in any duel you start
Scutum	shield	+1 to your defense in any duel
Pilum	javelin	+1 to your attack against the standing claimant
Pugio	dagger	you win tied duels
Galea	helmet	once per game, as your action: reveal any one face-down treasure card, wherever it is
Lorica segmentata	armor	once per game: when your claim is beaten, keep your square instead of returning to your gate

In a duel each side adds at most one item bonus - the best one that applies, never a sum. If you hold both the gladius and the pilum and attack the claimant, you still add only +1. Cross an item out on your sheet when its once-per-game ability is used.

You can keep collecting missing items during the succession phase. Nothing is ever granted for free - if you want it, walk and get it.

Prestige

Earning Prestige

- Guard post (star): end a move there and roll one die. A 4, 5 or 6 earns 1 Prestige.
- Win a duel: the winner of any duel earns 1 Prestige.

You can hold at most 3 Prestige. Any reward above three is lost - spend it or waste it.

Duels

End your move within two street circles of a rival and you may duel them as your action. The attacker and the defender each roll one die and add their best item bonus for that side. The higher total wins; on a tie the attacker wins - unless exactly one side holds the pugio, whose holder then wins the tie. The winner earns 1 Prestige. The loser pays 1 Prestige to the bank as shame, as much as they hold. Nobody loses equipment or support.

Spending Prestige

- 1 Prestige: one faction's support (next page).
- 1 Prestige: the mandatory fee to contest a proclaimed claim (next page).

Factions and the claim

The three factions

Three groups in the city can back your claim. Their meeting places are marked on the board with badges:

Faction	Badge	Meeting place
Army	shield	Treasure entry F
Imperial officials	column	one circle east of the Peristyle
City elites	laurel	Treasure entry A

Visit a meeting place and spend 1 Prestige to gain that faction's support. There is no roll. Every faction can support every player, but each faction supports each player only once. Support lasts the whole game. You may gain support in either phase of the game.

From the city to the succession

The game has two phases. In the city phase everyone collects equipment and Prestige. The first player who owns all six items may stand at the Peristyle and claim the checkpoint as their action. Finish that round, then one more full round, and the succession phase begins. If nobody claims by the end of round 24, the succession begins anyway.

At the change, every pawn stays where it stands and keeps everything it owns. Missing equipment is not granted - you can still walk and collect it.

Proclaiming a claim

1. During the succession phase, stand at the Peristyle with support from two different factions.
2. Use your action to proclaim your claim. Place the CLAIM marker on the Peristyle. Only one claim can stand at a time.
3. Your claim now stands inside a two-round window. Rivals may cancel it only by winning a challenge duel (next page). Turns that pass without a challenge no longer crown anyone by themselves.
4. If your turn comes while your claim stands and you are still at the Peristyle, you may maintain the claim as your action and stay put. Leaving the Peristyle by your own move cancels your claim.
5. If no rival cancels your claim before two full rounds have passed, you are emperor and the game ends.

Contesting a claim

How to contest

A rival can stop a claim by winning a challenge duel against the claimant. To do it, end your move within two street circles of the claimant and duel them. Challenging a standing claim costs a mandatory fee of 1 Prestige, paid before you roll - even if you lose. Without at least 1 Prestige you cannot contest at all.

The challenge itself is a normal duel: one die each, add your best item bonus, the pugio wins ties. A full challenge costs only the 1 Prestige fee.

What happens on each result

- You win: the claim is canceled. The claimant's pawn returns to their gate - unless they have not used the lorica segmentata, which once per game lets a beaten claimant keep their square (the claim still dies). They keep all equipment, Prestige and support either way. The next claim may be proclaimed at any time.
- You lose: the claim stands. Your Prestige is spent either way, and as in any duel the loser pays 1 Prestige shame to the bank.

An example challenge

Livia has proclaimed at the Peristyle with the Army and the elites behind her. Marcus, holding 2 Prestige, the gladius and the pilum, moves next to the crossing. He pays the 1 Prestige fee and duels. His best item bonus is +1 - the pilum also applies against a claimant, but one bonus only counts. He rolls 5 + 1 = 6. Livia holds the scutum and rolls 4 + 1 = 5. Marcus wins; the claim dies and Livia pays 1 Prestige shame. She has kept the lorica segmentata unused, so she stays at the crossing instead of walking back to her gate. Marcus earns 1 Prestige for the duel win, leaving him with 2.

If nobody wins

If no claim survives by the end of round 24 of the succession phase, the game ends in a draw - the throne stays empty. This is rare.

Remember

- An ordinary duel is free. Challenging a claim always costs the 1 Prestige fee.
- Everything is public: positions, items, Prestige, support, and who has claimed what. Only the four face-down cards and the next dice roll are hidden.

Common questions

Can I pass through another pawn?
Yes. Pawns never block a street.

Can two pawns share a circle?
Yes, any number may stand on one circle.

Do I have to use my whole roll?
No. Stop anywhere up to the total.

Can I duel the claimant for free while no claim stands?
Yes. Between claims the claimant is an ordinary rival and duels are free.

Can I challenge the same claim twice?
Yes - a failed challenge does not lock you out. Each attempt inside the window pays the fee again.

What if both duelists hold the pugio?
The normal tie rule applies: the attacker wins.

Does the galea let me name an item?
No. You name a district, not an item - the reveal turns up whatever card sits there.

What if I have 3 Prestige and win a guard roll?
Nothing happens - the cap is 3. Spend some first.

Can a faction support two different players?
Yes - every faction can back every player once.

Can I proclaim twice?
Yes, if your first claim is canceled, walk back and proclaim again. Support is never lost.

Can a claim be canceled after the window closes?
No. Two full rounds unchallenged and the game is over.

Do treasures run out?
No. Every player can mark each of the six items.

What if two players reach six items on the same round?
The first to claim at the Peristyle in turn order is the first challenger.

QUICK REFERENCE

keep this beside the board

YOUR TURN

1. Roll two dice.
2. Move up to the total; stop early if you like.
3. Do ONE action (or none): take treasure · guard duty · duel · gain support · claim the checkpoint · proclaim · maintain your claim.

ROLLS

Movement: two dice summed.

Guard post: one die - 4+ earns 1 Prestige.

Duel: one die each + your one best item bonus; the pugio wins ties.

EQUIPMENT (one best bonus per side)

Gladius +1 attack · Scutum +1 defense · Pilum +1 vs the claimant.

Pugio wins ties · Galea once: reveal a district · Lorica once: stay when beaten.

PRESTIGE (cap 3)

Earn: guard post 4+ · any duel win.

Spend: 1 = faction support · 1 = fee to contest a claim.

Lose: 1 to the bank whenever you lose a duel.

FACTIONS

Army (shield) at F · officials (column) one circle east of the Peristyle · elites (laurel) at A.

1 Prestige each, no roll, any phase. Two different factions needed to proclaim.

PROCLAIM

Succession phase, stand at the Peristyle, 2 supporters, no other claim standing.

CONTEST A CLAIM

Move within 2 circles of the claimant and duel them, any turn inside the window.

Mandatory fee: 1 Prestige before you roll.

Win: claim canceled, claimant returns to their gate (lorica: stay put once), keeps everything.

WINNING

A claim that stands two full rounds = emperor.

No claim standing by succession round 24 = draw.

TEACH IN FIVE MINUTES

read aloud - seven steps, then two short demonstrations

1. The goal (30 seconds)

"Diocletian has retired and the throne is empty. You will collect gear, win friends, and try to crown yourself. The claim your three rivals fail to stop inside two rounds wins the game."

2. Moving (30 seconds)

"On your turn, roll two dice and move up to the total along the white circles. Streets only - the hatched blocks are buildings. Stop anywhere. Then do one thing. That is a whole turn."

3. Equipment (45 seconds)

"The double circles A to F each hold one piece of gear - two start face up. Stop on one and mark it on your sheet. Each piece does one thing forever: the sword adds +1 to attacks, the shield +1 to defense, the javelin +1 against a claimant, the dagger wins ties, the helmet reveals a district once, the armor saves you once. In a duel you count your one best bonus - never a sum."

4. Prestige (60 seconds)

"This coin symbol is Prestige - political clout. Earn it at a star space: stop there, roll one die, 4 or higher pays 1. Win a duel: also 1. Lose a duel: pay 1 back to the bank. You can hold three. You will spend it on friends and on challenges."

5. Factions (45 seconds)

"Three groups can back you: the Army at F, the officials one circle east of the crossing, the elites at A. Walk to their meeting place and pay 1 Prestige - that faction now supports you for the rest of the game. Get two different factions behind you."

6. The endgame (60 seconds)

"When someone holds all six items they claim at the crossing - the Peristyle - and the succession begins: one more round, then the race to the throne. Stand at the Peristyle with two supporters and proclaim. Your rivals now have two full rounds to stop you: move next to you, pay 1 Prestige, and duel. Win the duel and the claim dies. Nobody does it in time and you are emperor."

7. Start (15 seconds)

"Random gates, random start, start moves clockwise each round. Youngest player rolls first if you like. Let's play."

Two tiny demonstrations

Ordinary turn: roll 8, walk eight circles to a star, roll one die - a 5 - and take a Prestige. Done.

Claim response: a rival proclaims at the Peristyle. On your turn, move next to them, put 1 Prestige aside (the fee), then each roll one die and add your one best item bonus. Higher total wins; the pugio wins ties.

Answer everything else when it comes up. Rare cases live in the rulebook, not in the introduction.

PLAYER SHEETS

one mat per player - mark with pencil or counters

PLAYER I

Name _____

Gate _____

EQUIPMENT (mark each item you collect)

- ☐ **Pugio** *wins tied duels*
- ☐ **Pilum** *+1 vs the claimant*
- ☐ **Galea** *once: reveal a district*
- ☐ **Scutum** *+1 defense*
- ☐ **Gladius** *+1 attack*
- ☐ **Lorica segmentata** *once: stay when beaten*

EQUIPMENT IN DUELS

Add your one best item bonus - never a sum.

PRESTIGE (hold at most 3 - extra is lost)

(1) (2) (3) *place one counter per point*

FACTION SUPPORT (2 different groups to proclaim)

- ☐ **Army**
- ☐ **Imperial officials**
- ☐ **City elites**

SUCCESSION REMINDERS

Support: visit the meeting place, pay 1 Prestige.
Proclaim: at the Peristyle with 2 different backers.
Claim window: a claim that stands 2 full rounds wins.
Contest a claim: pay the 1 Prestige fee, then duel.
Duel loser: pay 1 Prestige to the bank (shame).
Setup: two treasure districts start revealed.

PLAYER II

Name _____

Gate _____

EQUIPMENT (mark each item you collect)

- ☐ **Pugio** *wins tied duels*
- ☐ **Pilum** *+1 vs the claimant*
- ☐ **Galea** *once: reveal a district*
- ☐ **Scutum** *+1 defense*
- ☐ **Gladius** *+1 attack*
- ☐ **Lorica segmentata** *once: stay when beaten*

EQUIPMENT IN DUELS

Add your one best item bonus - never a sum.

PRESTIGE (hold at most 3 - extra is lost)

(1) (2) (3) *place one counter per point*

FACTION SUPPORT (2 different groups to proclaim)

- ☐ **Army**
- ☐ **Imperial officials**
- ☐ **City elites**

SUCCESSION REMINDERS

Support: visit the meeting place, pay 1 Prestige.
Proclaim: at the Peristyle with 2 different backers.
Claim window: a claim that stands 2 full rounds wins.
Contest a claim: pay the 1 Prestige fee, then duel.
Duel loser: pay 1 Prestige to the bank (shame).
Setup: two treasure districts start revealed.

PLAYER SHEETS

one mat per player - mark with pencil or counters

PLAYER III

Name _____

Gate _____

EQUIPMENT (mark each item you collect)

- ☐ **Pugio** *wins tied duels*
- ☐ **Pilum** *+1 vs the claimant*
- ☐ **Galea** *once: reveal a district*
- ☐ **Scutum** *+1 defense*
- ☐ **Gladius** *+1 attack*
- ☐ **Lorica segmentata** *once: stay when beaten*

EQUIPMENT IN DUELS

Add your one best item bonus - never a sum.

PRESTIGE (hold at most 3 - extra is lost)

(1) (2) (3) *place one counter per point*

FACTION SUPPORT (2 different groups to proclaim)

- ☐ **Army**
- ☐ **Imperial officials**
- ☐ **City elites**

SUCCESSION REMINDERS

Support: visit the meeting place, pay 1 Prestige.
Proclaim: at the Peristyle with 2 different backers.
Claim window: a claim that stands 2 full rounds wins.
Contest a claim: pay the 1 Prestige fee, then duel.
Duel loser: pay 1 Prestige to the bank (shame).
Setup: two treasure districts start revealed.

PLAYER IV

Name _____

Gate _____

EQUIPMENT (mark each item you collect)

- ☐ **Pugio** *wins tied duels*
- ☐ **Pilum** *+1 vs the claimant*
- ☐ **Galea** *once: reveal a district*
- ☐ **Scutum** *+1 defense*
- ☐ **Gladius** *+1 attack*
- ☐ **Lorica segmentata** *once: stay when beaten*

EQUIPMENT IN DUELS

Add your one best item bonus - never a sum.

PRESTIGE (hold at most 3 - extra is lost)

(1) (2) (3) *place one counter per point*

FACTION SUPPORT (2 different groups to proclaim)

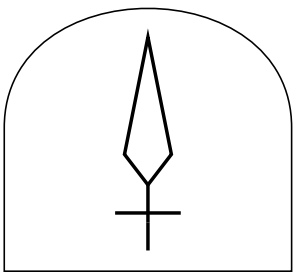
- ☐ **Army**
- ☐ **Imperial officials**
- ☐ **City elites**

SUCCESSION REMINDERS

Support: visit the meeting place, pay 1 Prestige.
Proclaim: at the Peristyle with 2 different backers.
Claim window: a claim that stands 2 full rounds wins.
Contest a claim: pay the 1 Prestige fee, then duel.
Duel loser: pay 1 Prestige to the bank (shame).
Setup: two treasure districts start revealed.

TREASURE LOCATION CARDS

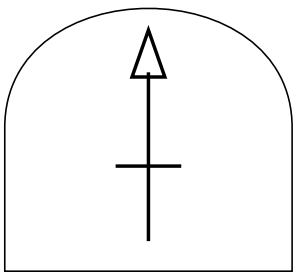
cut on the outer border - identical backs on the next page



PUGIO

Wins tied duels.

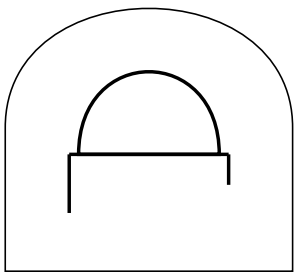
PALACE TREASURE - LOCATION CARD



PILUM

+1 attack vs the claimant.

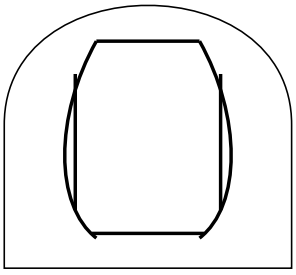
PALACE TREASURE - LOCATION CARD



GALEA

Once a game: reveal any district.

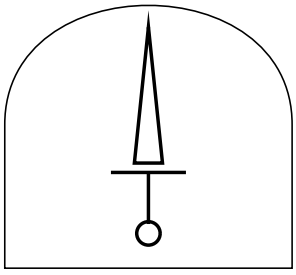
PALACE TREASURE - LOCATION CARD



SCUTUM

+1 to your defense.

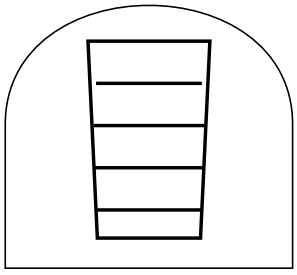
PALACE TREASURE - LOCATION CARD



GLADIUS

+1 to your attack.

PALACE TREASURE - LOCATION CARD



LORICA SEGMENTATA

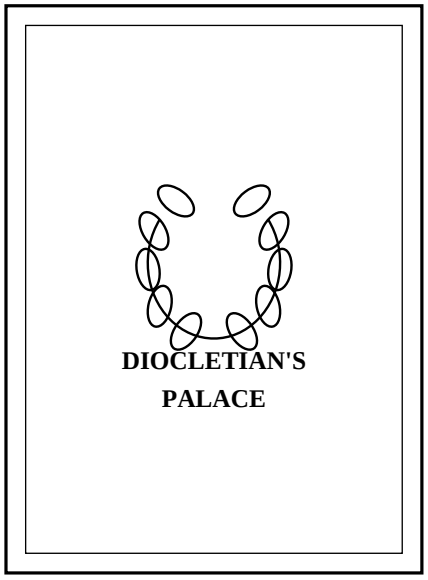
Once: a beaten claimant stays put.

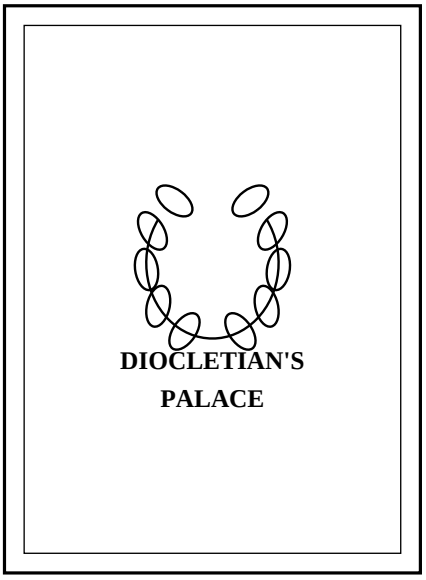
PALACE TREASURE - LOCATION CARD

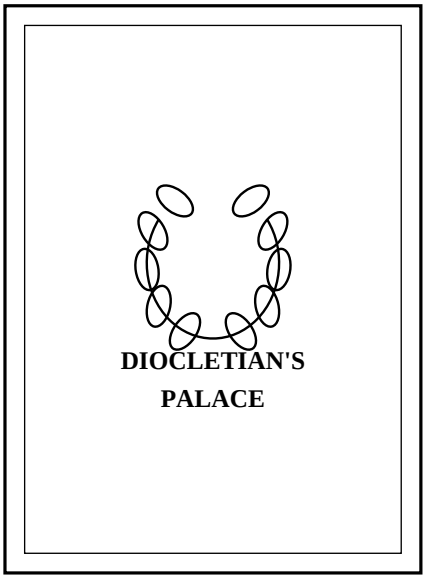
Shuffle face down and deal one card to each treasure entry A-F. Then turn two of the six face up at random - everyone sees those two treasures from the start. Each card states its ability; in a duel count one best bonus per side, never a sum.

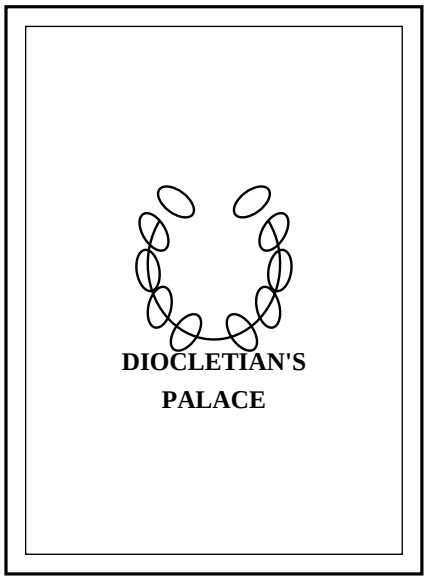
CARD BACKS

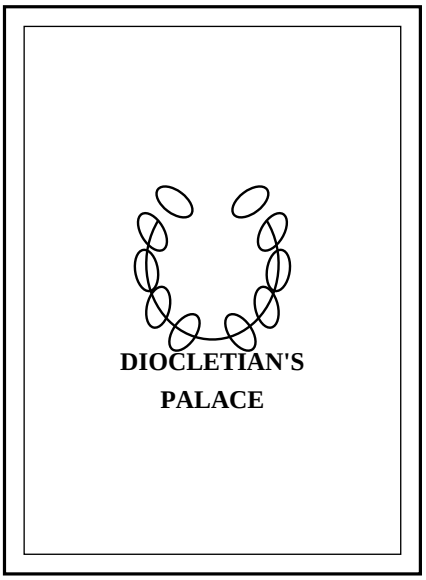
six identical tiles - glue or fold behind each card

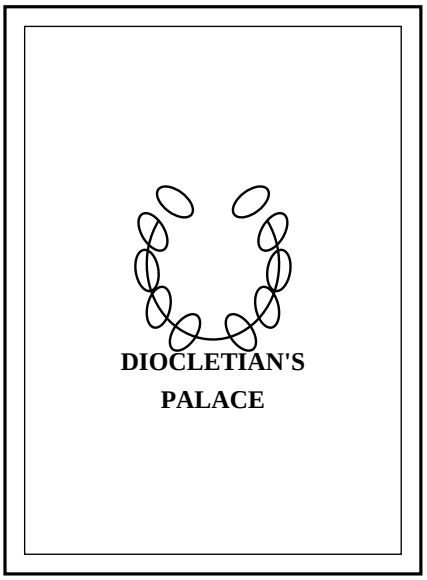












TOKENS

cut out - fold the pawns and tape them upright

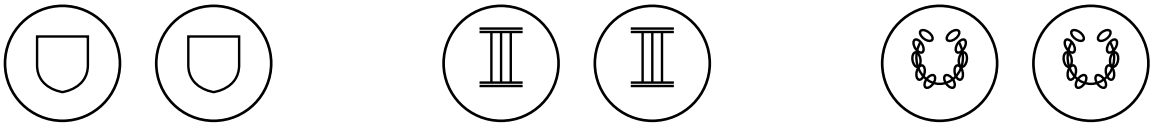
PLAYER PAWNS (fold in half, tape or glue)

I	**I**	**II**	**II**	**III**	**III**	**IV**	**IV**
fold		fold		fold		fold	

PRESTIGE COUNTERS (16)

1 PRESTIGE	**1** PRESTIGE	**1** PRESTIGE	**1** PRESTIGE	**1** PRESTIGE	**1** PRESTIGE	**1** PRESTIGE	**1** PRESTIGE
1 PRESTIGE	**1** PRESTIGE	**1** PRESTIGE	**1** PRESTIGE	**1** PRESTIGE	**1** PRESTIGE	**1** PRESTIGE	**1** PRESTIGE

FACTION SUPPORT MARKERS (2 of each)



PENDING CLAIM MARKER

CLAIM

pending

FIRST CHALLENGER MARKER

FIRST

challenger

Place FIRST CHALLENGER on the board when a player claims the checkpoint. It marks the round when the succession phase will begin.

ROUND AND PHASE TRACK

City phase (max 24 rounds): ☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐

Succession phase (max 24 rounds): ☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐

6 12 18 24

The city phase ends 1 full round after the first checkpoint claim (or at round 24). Track rounds only if you use the 24-round limits.

PLAYTEST RECORD

observations only - no invented results

GROUP

Players: ____ Ages: _____ _____ _____ _____

Group type: family with children / adult non-gamers / strategy players / older first-timers

Minutes to explain the rules: _____ Total game duration (minutes): _____

UNDERSTANDING (ask each player alone)

Who could explain how someone wins, without help? P1 / P2 / P3 / P4

Why does collecting equipment help later? _____

Name one treasure and what it does: _____

What is Prestige for? Name two ways to get it. _____

A rival just proclaimed a claim. What can you do? _____

CLARITY

Rules clarifications needed (count): _____ Most asked:

Confusing spaces or symbols:

Record with this form: gate assignment, rounds played, and any rules you improvised. Do not fill in anything that did not happen.

PLAYTEST RECORD

observations only - no invented results

THE NEW BOARD

Did anyone cross the middle for B, E or the inner stars? yes / hardly / no

Did the two start-revealed treasures change first moves? yes / no

Gate distances felt fair? P0 ____ P1 ____ P2 ____ P3 ____

THE CLAIM

Claims proclaimed: ____ Challenged: ____ Canceled: ____ Crowned: ____

Did the two-round claim window feel tense or empty? _____

First completed set - prize or burden? _____ Best treasure: ____ Worst: ____

ENGAGEMENT

Did a player fall behind but stay involved? yes / partly / no Who: _____

Waiting between turns: where and how long? _____

AGAIN?

Want to play again? P1 yes/maybe/no P2 ____ P3 ____ P4 ____

What would they try differently next time?

One thing to change: _____

Record with this form: gate assignment, rounds played, and any rules you improvised. Do not fill in anything that did not happen.